had left Africa at least 70,000 years ago and settled in the subcontinent at least 65,000 years ago.[6] The second group was a population of West Asian hunter-gatherers who migrated to the subcontinent before the advent of agriculture in the Fertile Crescent. It now appears that agriculture either arose independently in the subcontinent, or was imported in subsequent millennia by cultural rather than genetic diffusion from West Asia.[7]

As with other ancient civilizations, the Harappan Civilization largely arose along rivers and coasts. The rivers included the Indus and the extinct Ghaggar-Hakra (some scholars, with contested evidence and dubious motivation, call this the Saraswati River of the *Rig Veda*).[8] Scores of sites in Gujarat like Dholavira, Lothal and Surkotada arose on the Arabian Sea coast, or along nearby rivers. 'Indus Valley Civilization' is therefore inaccurate; many scholars prefer 'Harappan Civilization', honouring a convention in which the first discovered site's name is adopted for the whole.

As elsewhere, the Harappan Civilization too was marked by a set of advanced skills and practices. These include 'domestication of animals; cultivation of wheat, barley, and other grains; growing of fruits; building of houses; organization of society in cities; spinning and weaving of [cotton] textiles and dyeing them various colors; the use of the potter's wheel and the decoration of wares; river [and sea] navigation; the use of wheeled vehicles; the working of metal [copper, tin, arsenic, lead, silver, gold and electrum]; writing; fashioning of ornaments from faience, ivory, bone, shell, and semiprecious stones'.[9]

Harappan cities had specialized trades, markets, the fanciest goods and high culture, and had smaller towns and villages around them. City dwellers traded with farmers and herders in villages, and probably also with nomadic people and hunter-gatherer tribes in nearby forests. From the villages and the hinterlands, the city-dwellers received raw materials like metals, semi-precious stones, timber and, of course, food grains, conveyed by bullock carts or pack animals. There is no evidence that Dholavira was the capital of a unified region, but it seems reasonable to speculate that it was a trading hub for scores of Harappan sites and other nearby peoples. Archaeologist